Rumors

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

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by EmperorNorton150

Summary

It's lonely being the one in charge. The one everyone depends on. The one everyone expects to fix everything.

It helps to have someone to talk to about it.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Catra had first learned how to navigate the Fright Zone's ventilation system as a cadet. It had been useful, for avoiding Shadow Weaver and Octavia, for getting out of chores and training sessions, for sneaking past guards and other cadets. Now she was Generalissimo, Supreme Commander of the Horde, ruler of half of Etheria. And they were still useful. Useful for avoiding her more troublesome Force Captains, for getting out of formal occasions and particularly boring meetings, and—for listening.

Claws sheathed, Catra padded silently down the corroded metal tube, ears cocked, listening to the voices of the Horde. *Workers in the fabrication plants complaining about shortages of iridium and phosphates. Cadets boasting about a victory in a training match. A pair of sentries chatting about the new pension plans. A diplomat from the Kingdom of Skull Path, arguing about tribute payment with his advisors.* Questions, complaints, discourse, discussion, it flowed like a river through the hallways and towers of the Fright Zone, and Catra immersed herself in it. Oh *sure*, she had reports and memos and briefs that summarized everything she theoretically needed to know but—it wasn't the same as *hearing* it. She'd first discovered that as a Force Captain, trying to wrangle her troops into battle. You developed a sense for it, after a while, an instinct for what was important, what it all meant. Ruling the Horde was like balancing on the edge of a knife sometimes. She needed every advantage she could get.

"Oh yeah, the Generalissimo and I basically grew up together. I know *all* about her." She stopped, frowning. That voice was……familiar. Obnoxious, brash, suffused with a smug sense of superiority….

"Wow!"

"Really sir?"

"Oh yeah. I mean, I wouldn't say we were *friends* or anything, it's not like Her Excellency's ever had much use for those. But…..I'd say I knew her as well as anyone else." She had

it! Team Leader Gorgon, senior cadet from the bunkroom right next to theirs. Bloody Stars, he'd been an insufferable little jerk, and it didn't sound like he'd changed much. He was……a lieutenant now, in the 32nd Light Infantry. With a smirk, she folded herself around the ventilation grate. *This* ought to be good.

"What was it like sir?"

"Were you in the same barracks?"

"Could you tell she'd end up ruling the Horde?" The voices of the junior officers overlapped in a chorus of eager questions. Gorgon chuckled in that way of his—practiced and disdainful. Catra had forgotten how annoying it was.

"Well now, I don't know about anyone else but *I* certainly thought little Catra was bound for the upper ranks. She was a clever little cadet, you know. Sneaky, sly, vicious—when poor old Octavia tried to put her back in her place the little kitty carved her eye out! We used to talk, now and then, about the Horde and our future—" Catra stifled a giggle. As she recalled, their main topic of conversation had been him trying to order her to clean up his squad's messes and her telling him to get lost. "—and you could always tell she had a plan. Other cadets spent their time daydreaming or malingering, but Catra? She was *planning*. Always. Poor Shadow Weaver didn't stand a chance. And neither did Adora." Something flashed in front of Catra's eyes, and her claws tightened on the metal walls of the shaft. She took a deep breath, in and out, in and out, and forced herself to untense.

"I always wondered how she'd gotten rid of Shadow Weaver" one of the junior troops was saying. She must have missed part of the conversation. "I mean, people say that witch was terrifying—"

"They're right," said Gorgon. His voice sounded less cocky for a moment, and Catra could hear him swallow. "She was, uhhhh, she was something, alright. But she's gone now. Anyways! You wanna hear how our Generalissimo got rid of her?" There was

a chorus of voices yelling assent. "Alright, alright. Let me tell you, I was right there when most of this went down." Bedsprings squealed as he shifted down below. "Well now, it all started three or four years ago. Hordak ruled the Horde and Shadow Weaver was his right-hand-witch and Shadow Weaver had a little pet, Adora. You kids just know her as the legendary protector of Etheria and all that—" his voice dipped into a sneer for a moment "—but when I was a cadet, she was still hanging around here. Now, Adora was good, don't get me wrong. Why, she even used to beat me in the sparring ring sometimes—" *she beat you every time you pretentious twit* thought Catra "—but she was *soft*. Didn't understand what it meant to be a warrior. A soldier! Shadow Weaver didn't see any of that though, and it was clear to us all that Adora was being groomed as her top commander. Most of us just resigned ourselves. Not Catra though!" He chuckled. "Those two always used to hang out together. They were inseparable! None of us really understood it—I mean, Adora was next in line for a Force Captain's badge, and Catra was clinging to the bottom of the ranking tables. But that clever little kitty cat had a plan. She spent *years* putting up a false front. She let Shadow Weaver think she was lazy, weak, stupid. And she let Adora think that they were friends. And so, nobody was expecting when she *struck*."

"Not even you sir?" asked one of the younger soldiers.

"Oh, I knew she was up to *something*. But I couldn't guess how she'd pull it off. You see, we all thought Adora was Shadow Weaver's greatest strength, her top-scoring cadet, loyal to the death. Catra figured out that she was her *weakness*. And *that's* why she tricked her into defecting to the rebels." Catra's jaw dropped. There was a babble of voices from below.

"How'd she manage that?" somebody called.

"Beats me!" laughed Gorgon. "Adora never had the stomach for *real* war though, and Catra knew it. I think she lured her out into the woods, put her in contact with some rebels—she knew Adora would fall for their silly lies right away—made sure

she was there at Thaymor when we attacked. Adora got in the way, of course, and hey! Now she's a traitor and she's got no choice but to throw her lot in with the princesses and Catra gets that promised Force Captain's badge instead. But that's not the important part. Remember, Adora was Shadow Weaver's special project. So, Adora runs off to join the rebels. That makes Shadow Weaver look bad. She can't have that. She gets *obsessed* with dragging the traitor back here. She starts ignoring other missions, neglecting her duties, forgetting about plans…..and guess who picks up all that slack?"

"Catra….." someone whispered in an awe-stricken voice.

"Yup. Shadow Weaver is so fixated on getting Adora back that she doesn't even notice that Catra's been taking her place. And each time the witch failed…….well, Hordak didn't approve of failure, let me tell you. When Catra finally moved against Shadow Weaver, she did it with the big boss's full support. And that old sorceress was so busy chasing Adora she didn't realize it until it was too late."

"That's brilliant….."

"Did she really plan the whole thing out like that?"

"Trust me, our Generalissimo is *always* planning like that. Always scheming. Watch your back if you're near her! That's why she's the boss. Why, I remember another time, back when we were cadets, and—" The metal wall crumpled under Catra's grip with a *screech*, prompting shouts of alarm.

"What was that?!"

"Hordak's teeth, do you think the ceiling's collapsing?"

"Calm down, calm down, it's probably just those rats again…." The voices faded into the background as Catra fled down the ventilation shaft, a single thought echoing through her mind.

Did I really do all that?

Adora wouldn't have overheard them if she hadn't had been late to the council meeting. But she'd lost track of time during her sparring session, and was trying to make up for it by taking a shortcut around one of the inner courtyards. She could hear the voices drifting up from down below as she sprinted down the walkway when a stray sentence caught her ear.

"……look, all I'm saying is that if she *is* She-Ra—" Adora stopped, despite herself. Peering over the balustrade, she saw a dozen guardsmen on break, sprawled around a pair of tables set in the midst of a topiary garden, the remains of a noonday meal scattered around them. One of the was holding forth quite avidly.

"*If*? You haven't noticed the magic sword? The flying horse? That the girl's eight-feet tall half the time?" broke in one of his compatriots with a laugh. "Were you not there at the Battle of Bright Moon or the Second Battle of Elberon?"

"Yes, yes, she's clearly a Princess. But don't you remember the old stories? The She-Ra was supposed to bring balance to Etheria, usher in a golden age of some kind—"

"Wow, you're complaining because not everything's perfect?"

"Shut up and let me talk! Like I said, she's supposed to be the incarnation of Etheria and the protector of the planet and all that and what has she done?"

"We're at peace, aren't we?" a third soldier called out. "Stop whining." Adora leaned further out over the edge, trying to hear better.

"We're *allied* to the Horde!" snapped the first one. "That's not what I call peace!"

"Nobody's getting killed anymore" said the second guardsmen flatly, playing with his sword. "That's good enough for me."

"In my grandfather's day Bright Moon still held Colonia and the riverlands and the Western Marches all the way to—"

"Oh, *who cares!* Lost Stars, before Adora showed up we were losing ground to the Horde each year. Now we have peace thanks to her. Stop moaning about lost glories you old windbag."

"Well, *technically*" said another guardsman, coughing to draw attention to himself. "Ahem! Technically, we have Generalissimo Catra to thank for our current state of peace. She was the one to initiate the negotiations, as I do recall."

"Like I said! It was a surrender! A surrender to the Horde!" shouted the first one, pounding his fist on the table. The second soldier rolled his eyes.

"You did *not*. Anyways, what does it matter who started the negotiations? The point is that the cursed war's finally over. You wanna go back to fighting bots all day, do it on your own time. Leave us out of it." There was a rumble of agreement.

"On the contrary my friend, it matters a *great deal* who started the negotiations" spoke up the fourth guardsman again. "We wouldn't have a peace treaty if it wasn't for Catra."

"Well yeah, I mean Hordak wouldn't have—"

"No, no. I mean, yes, but that's not what I meant. What matters is that we're talking about Catra. *Adora's Catra.*" Adora gasped, then covered her mouth. Luckily, nobody heard.

"What exactly are you implying?" growled the second soldier.

"Look friends, we all know that our Adora and Generalismo Catra, Supreme Commander of the Horde (etc, etc) grew up together. We all know how hard Adora tried to get Catra to defect, and how much it upset her that she failed. I don't blame her! That sort of thing's a strong bond. But I do think that,

hmmm, let us say the Horde may have gotten a better deal out of She-Ra than they might've otherwise, yes?"

"No, let us *not* say! Our Queen endorsed that treaty, remember? Anyways, if She-Ra and Catra being old friends helped end the war……good! I'm glad the war's over, and so is the sovereign we swore an oath of allegiance to, and more to the point, so's General Juliet! So pipe down before she hears and sends you out to patrol the Whispering Woods for a month!"

"Look" said the first soldier after a long pause, lowering his voice. "I'm not—I like the kid, ok? And I don't mind peace. But this won't last forever. The Horde's still there, and someday, it'll have a new leader, and the war'll begin again. And that's not even *mentioning* Horde Prime, if he really exists and that crazy princess didn't just make him up. Face it, She-Ra hasn't fulfilled any of the prophecies. She hasn't balanced the planet, she hasn't ended the threat of the Horde, she—" Adora had been leaning farther and farther out between the pillars of the railing, trying to hear. All of a sudden, her hand slipped on the smooth stone, and with a jolt she started to tumble. Before she had time to shout or panic, a blast of wind whirled across the courtyard, scattering cups and plates and hats, and gently lifting Adora back onto the walkway. She whirled around to see Spinnerella smiling at her.

They walked in silence until they reached the entrance back into the main structure of the castle. Sliding the door shut behind her, Spinnerella said

"I would ignore the rumors if I were you. People will say anything when they're bored, and it usually all blows over by the end of the week anyways. That's part of why 'tossa and I spend so much time away from court."

"Rumors? What rumors?" Adora tried to laugh. "Haha! I wasn't listening to anything." Unexpectedly, Spinnerella hugged her.

"You've done more than enough for us dear. I just don't want you feeling guilty because of some silly fools talking nonsense."

"I'm *fine*, really! But thanks."

"All right, if you're sure. Let's go then. Queen Angella sent me to find you when you didn't show up for the—"

"The council meeting! Oh my gosh, I totally forgot about that!" Adora spinted off down the hall. Spinnerella laughed, shook her head, and followed more sedately.

Catra stood by the desert table, trying not to scream. She hated crowds. Always had. Give her a corner or a ventilation shaft or a rooftop, somewhere where she could watch her back and keep an eye on everybody else. Crowds made her nervous, and when she was nervous, her claws started to come out. That would be…… particularly inadvisable right now. She understood that her invitation to the Festival of Lost Stars was a mark of respect. She was even grateful to Glimmer for the gesture. It hadn't been as bad as she'd thought it'd be—the Queen had been gracious, she'd managed to work in a discussion about the negotiations with King Gruff with sparkles, and even Mermista had been surprisingly civil. It still wasn't easy for her. Clumps of people flowed across the Great Hall of Bluestone Castle, grazing at tables laden with food and drink or chattering loudly. Overhead hung grey and black banners, spangled with flashes of silver and gold. She made a mental note to ask sparkles exactly what a star *was* at some point. Over by the bar she could hear Scorpia trying to make conversation with that flower princess.

"Hi! I'm General Scorpia Force, I mean Force Scorpia Genera, oh gosh, I mean Force General Scorpia—"

"Hello! I'm so glad the universe has decided to bring us together today!"

"Oooh wow, flowers, thank you! That's so cool, I mean, of course you can make flowers that's like, you're whole thing haha!"

"So what's it like being Force General? It sounds so exciting!"

"Aw well, you know, it has its moments—" There was a bray of laughter from a drunken satyr and Catra had to prick her palm with the tips of her claws to keep herself from doing something she'd regret. Then—footsteps behind her, audible even through the cacophony. Smoothing her face into a mask of ironic amusement, she turned.

"Hey Adora." The other girl yelped in surprise.

"How'd you know it was me?" she demanded. She was wearing a white and gold dress that seemed to shimmer in the lamplight. *It matches my uniform* thought Catra, and for reason felt obscurely pleased by that. Not wanting to admit she could recognize the sound of Adora's footsteps she just flicked her ears.

"Oh well—you know" she said vaguely. There was a *crash* and a burst of yelps and shouts from the far side of the room as a guest lost control of his glass of wine and Catra jumped, fur bristling.

"Oh *no!*" said Adora "I forgot how much you hate crowds. Are you ok? Do you need help? Do you wanna go outside? Do you—what? What it is?" Catra had started snickering uncontrollably.

"The last time we were in a place like this" said the Generalismo of the Horde, flicking her tail, "I blew up the building, got you arrested, and kidnapped your friends—and you're worried that *I* might be uncomfortable?" Adora flushed.

"Oh. Yeah. I mean—sorry?" Catra waved her hand.

"It's fine. You're incorrigible, you know that?"

"Yeah!" There was a moment of silence. "So, uhh. What have you been up to lately?" Catra shrugged.

"This and that. Negotiating with the Kingdom of Greenvale over military transit rights. There's a new hydroelectric project out by the Boiling Sea that looks really promising, I'm supposed to go inspect that soon. We're getting ready for our next move against the Snake-Men but, ahhh, I can't really talk about that, y'know? Operational security." Adora nodded.

"I get it."

"So. Um. What about you?"

"Oh, I don't know. Trying to keep busy helping people. Still haven't saved the world yet!" Catra caught her eye and the grin Adora had pasted on slipped away.

"Does that still bother you?"

"A little bit?" Adora admitted. Catra sighed.

"Adora, of all the things—you'll figure it out. I wouldn't worry." Adora frowned.

"Why are you so sure?"

"Because that's who you are." She sounded almost sad. "Whatever has to be done, you'll do it, no matter the consequences. If you really *are* supposed the save the world or vanquish evil or whatever, when the time comes—I don't have any doubts about what'll happen."

"Catra, I—"

"Forget it" she snapped.

"No, really" said Adora. She reached out as if to touch the other girl's shoulder but then drew her hand back. "That

means a lot to me. Coming from you, I mean." Catra didn't say anything for a long moment.

"It wasn't fake." Adora blinked.

"What?"

"When we—when we were friends. Before you aband—before you left. I really did care about you." Catra was fiddling with one of the epaulets on her uniform, not looking at Adora. "I just wanted you to know that." Adora stared at her.

"Well yeah! Of course! Did you……did you think I didn't believe that?" Catra flicked her ears.

"I've…….heard stuff" she muttered. "And after all, I'm the Generalismo of the Horde. The person who stabbed Shadow Weaver and Hordak in the back. The ruthless one, the treacherous one, the one who only cares about power—" she realized her voice was getting louder, and people nearby were starting to stare. "I wouldn't blame you for not believing me" she said more quietly.

"Well, that's stupid. Of *course* you cared about me. You wouldn't have gone so crazy if you hadn't!" She clapped a hand over her mouth but Catra just laughed.

"Well, that's one way of putting it."

"Seriously Catra—you care. You care a *lot*. Maybe not about all of the same things I do but—you care."

"Thank you" whispered Catra, blinking rapidly. Something must have gotten into her eyes.

"It's lonely, isn't it?" said Adora.

"Hmm?"

"Being the one everyone depends on. Being the one in charge, the one who's supposed to fix everything."

"Yeah" said Catra. "Yeah, it is. But……it's kinda nice to talk to someone else who understands that."

"Agreed" There was a companionable silence for a few moments, the buzz of conversation and laughter filling the space between them. From somewhere in the distance floated the sound of Sea Hawk singing.

"About Thaymor—" said Adora. Catra put up a hand, cutting her off.

"No. I can't—I don't want to talk about that. Not now. Maybe some other time, but not now. Please?"

"Ok" said Adora. "Whatever you want." On the far side of the room there was a fanfare of horns, heralding the next phase of the entertainment. As the strains of a waltz filled the air, guests began to form couples and drift into the middle of the floor. All of a sudden, Adora grabbed Catra's hand.

"C'mon!" she said. "You owe me a dance." Catra raised an eyebrow.

"I do?" Adora nodded vigorously.

"The last time we danced you blew up the building halfway through. So you owe me one." Catra ginned.

"Ok" she said. "Let's go."

She put her hand on Adora's waist, and they walked out together to dance under a sea of shining stars.

End Notes

- I was planning to do a big plot-advancing story next but I've been stuck on it for, like, two months now so I decided to write a shorter character piece instead.

- I'm always interested in how other people in the universe, who don't have all the information we do, view the events of the main story-line.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!